

Lob Defense

1. Lesson Recap

Lob defense is how you recover when an opponent floats the ball high over your head toward the baseline, trying to push you off the kitchen line. Instead of panicking or backpedaling blindly, you turn, track the ball, and either take it out of the air with an overhead or chase it down and reset the point.

The goal of lob defense is not always to win the point outright. Most of the time, your job is to survive the lob, neutralize the attack, and get back to the kitchen line as a team. A calm, well-defended lob takes away your opponent's "easy" weapon and keeps you in the rally.

A key safety point: never backpedal flat-footed with your eyes up. That is how players fall and get hurt. Turn your body and run, or shuffle, so you stay balanced and in control.

2. Big Idea

When you get lobbed, turn and go get it — don't backpedal.

The single most important habit is to rotate your shoulders, drop-step, and move like you are running, not shuffle backward off your heels. Turning lets you cover ground quickly and safely, and it keeps you balanced enough to actually hit a usable shot.

3. Key Cues

- "Turn, don't backpedal."
- "Drop-step with the outside foot."
- "Eyes on the ball, lead with the shoulders."
- "Take it in the air if you can."
- "If it's deep, run past it, then hit moving forward."
- "Call it: 'Mine!' or 'Switch!'"
- "Reset deep and low — buy time."
- "Get back to the line together."
- "Stay calm, one ball at a time."

4. Step-by-Step

1. Read it early. Watch for an opponent opening the paddle face and dropping low — that often signals a lob is coming.
2. The instant you see it go up, turn your hips and shoulders toward the side the ball is traveling. Do not square up and step straight back.
3. Drop-step with your outside foot, then move with a crossover run or quick shuffles, keeping your eyes on the ball.
4. Decide: can you reach it before it bounces? If yes, set up under it and hit an overhead at the highest comfortable contact point.
5. If it is too deep to take in the air, run past where it will land so the ball ends up in front of you, not over your head.
6. Let it bounce, then hit while moving forward. A reset or third-shot-style drop into the kitchen is usually smarter than a risky power shot.
7. Communicate. Call "Mine!" if you take it, and "Switch!" if you and your partner need to swap sides because you crossed behind them.
8. Recover. As soon as you make contact, hustle back toward the kitchen line with your partner so you reset your team to a strong position.

5. Common Mistakes

- Backpedaling on your heels: Stepping straight back with your eyes up is slow and dangerous. Turn and run or shuffle instead so you stay balanced and avoid falling.
- Reaching back over your head: Trying to swat a deep lob from behind your body produces weak, off-balance shots. Run past the ball so you can hit it moving forward.
- Trying to win every lob: Smashing a tough overhead from deep in the court often sails out or pops up. When you are scrambling, a calm reset keeps you in the point.
- Going for the overhead too late: If you let a reachable lob bounce, you give up your best offensive option. Take it in the air whenever you comfortably can.
- No communication: Both partners chasing the same lob, or neither calling "switch," leads to confusion and open court. Talk early and loudly.
- Standing too close to the line all the time: Camping right on the kitchen line makes you an easy lob target. A step back during a heavy lobbing exchange buys reaction time.

6. Self-Check

- Did I turn and run instead of backpedaling?
- Did I lead with my shoulders and keep my eyes on the ball?
- Could I have taken that one out of the air with an overhead?
- Did I run past the deep ball so I could hit moving forward?
- Did I choose a safe reset when I was scrambling, instead of forcing a winner?
- Did I call "Mine!" or "Switch!" with my partner?
- Did I get back to the kitchen line with my partner after the shot?

7. Homework 🏠

Practice these before your next play session:

- Drop-step turn drill: Stand at the kitchen line. Have a partner point left or right; immediately drop-step with the outside foot and turn that direction. Do 15 turns each side to build the reflex to turn instead of backpedal.
- Overhead feed drill: Have a partner feed easy lobs you can reach. Set up under the ball and hit 20 controlled overheads, aiming for placement and clean contact at a high point, not maximum power.
- Chase-and-reset drill: Have a partner lob deep over your head. Turn, run past the ball, let it bounce, and hit a soft shot back into the kitchen while moving forward. Do 10 reps and focus on balance and a controlled reset.
- Switch communication drill: With a partner at the kitchen line, take turns chasing lobs and loudly calling "Switch!" while crossing behind each other. Do 10 reps so the call and the movement become automatic.
- Shadow footwork: With no ball, practice the turn-and-crossover-run pattern for 2 minutes. Smooth, safe movement is the foundation of good lob defense.
- Awareness task: During recreational play, notice which opponents lob and what their body looks like just before they do it. Start reading the lob earlier.

8. Game Application 🎮

Use lob defense any time the ball goes up over your head — but let the situation pick your shot for you. If you can get set under the ball, take it out of the air with an overhead and stay on offense. If it is over your head and deep, shift your mindset from "attack" to "survive and reset."

Do not try to be a hero from the back of the court. A scrambled overhead or a low-percentage drive usually hands the point away. Running the ball down and dropping it softly into the kitchen, then getting back to the line, wins far more points over a match.

In doubles, lob defense is a team play. Whoever has the best angle takes the ball, the partner covers, and you switch sides when needed. Talk constantly, reset together, and remember that neutralizing the lob and getting back to the line is a win in itself. Stay patient — most lobbers eventually make the error if you keep returning the ball.

9. Visualization 👁️

Before you play, picture yourself settled at the kitchen line, relaxed and alert. You see your opponent open the paddle face and lean back, and you recognize the lob early.

The instant the ball climbs, imagine yourself turning your shoulders, drop-stepping, and running smoothly under it. You feel balanced and in control, eyes locked on the ball. In one version, you set up underneath and hit a crisp overhead at full reach. In another, the lob is deep, so you run past it, let it bounce, and calmly push a soft drop back into the kitchen. You call to your partner, switch sides, and the two of you glide back to the line together, ready for the next ball.

10. Quick Reminders

- Turn and run — never backpedal flat-footed.
- Take it in the air whenever you can.
- If it's deep, run past it and hit moving forward.
- Scrambling? Reset soft and deep instead of forcing a winner.
- Talk: "Mine!" and "Switch!"
- Get back to the kitchen line with your partner.
- Stay calm and play one ball at a time.

11. Resources

Use these resources for optional review away from the court. The lesson notes above are your main practice plan.

Articles

- [Pickleball Lob Shots](#)
Source: USA Pickleball
An overview of how lobs work on both offense and defense, including why anticipation and positioning are your first line of defense.
- [Pickleball Lobs – How and When To Use Them](#)
Source: Pickleheads
A clear guide that covers reading the lob, footwork to recover, and how to choose between an overhead and a defensive reset.
- [Pickleball Lob Shots: Using and Defending The Lob](#)
Source: Sarah Ansboury Pickleball Academy
Coaching-focused tips on turning instead of backpedaling, tracking the ball safely, and getting your team back into position.

YouTube Videos

- [How To Defend The Lob | What to do when you have to chase down a lob](#)
Channel: PrimeTime Pickleball
Walks through what to do when a good lob gets over your head: chase it down, reset it into the kitchen, and recover to the line without panicking.
- [5 Steps to DEFEND the Pickleball Lob \(Super Simple!\)](#)
Channel: Better Pickleball
A simple, beginner-friendly five-step system for reading the lob, using shuffle steps for short lobs, and running down deep ones.
- [Defend Against the Pickleball Lob](#)
Channel: Selkirk TV
Coach Linda Thompson explains what to look for before a lob, how to move to defend it, and how to prevent giving up easy lobs in the first place.

Rules and Strategy References

- [Defending the Lob in Doubles Pickleball: The Passive Approach](#)
Source: The Dink Pickleball
Explains doubles positioning and the partner "switch" so you understand who chases the lob and how the team rotates to cover the open court.
- [USA Pickleball Rules Summary](#)
Source: USA Pickleball
A quick rules reference that confirms you may run behind the baseline and switch sides freely while defending, so you can chase a lob without fear of a fault.